Into the Light

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Micah & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Not Canon Compliant, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Emotions, Angst, Battle, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Beast Island (She-Ra), dealing with some issues

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Part 14 of Catra's Coup

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by EmperorNorton150

Summary

Adora and Catra track Shadow Weaver to her secret lair on Beast Island. But to defeat her they'll need to learn how to deal with ancient secrets, treachery, lies, monstrous beasts--and each other.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

The spire rose above the jungle canopy, a jagged pillar of basalt and concrete and strange metals, etched with First Ones symbols which seemed to pulse in the dim, sullen light. It loomed above the two girls who pushed through the underbrush onto the causeway leading up towards the open gate.

"Sooo" asked Adora. "You think this is it?" Catra snorted.

"Ominous tower? Weird purple light? An itching in my teeth? Seems like Shadow Weaver's kind of place to *me*."

"Right" said Adora, nodding. "Ok. Got it." Her hand clenched at the hilt of her sword. Catra glanced at her.

"You alright?"

"Yeah! I'm fine. I'm good. It's just—does this feel a little too easy to you?" Catra's ears flicked and she scowled at the surrounding jungle.

"Maybe…..maybe a little bit. I expected a few more beasts from Beast Island." It had been two hours since Swift Wind had dropped them off on the shoreline, complaining bitterly that they weren't taking him with them into the *deadly jungle deathtrap*. Except……the island had been weirdly empty. Some creeping vines, a plant that had tried to eat them, and one or two giant lizards but mostly it was just……empty. Not empty like it was abandoned, empty like it was sleeping. Catra could feel eyes watching her. She didn't like it. And her teeth itched. And there was a buzzing in her head that just wouldn't go away. She didn't like it. "Let's just get this over with" she said finally.

"Right!" said Adora. The other girl rubbed at her head, then drew her sword.

"C'mon" Catra growled, flexing her claws. "Let's go."

Footsteps echoed on the ancient floor as they passed through the gate. Silvery metal doors lay on the ground where some force had ripped them asunder. Then there was a long corridor, doors sealed shut or smashed open, the only from a few lightsticks glued to the wall. Their shadows danced creepily along the walls.

"Footprints" murmured Adora, gesturing to the floor. "Lots of them."

"I see them" Catra replied under her breath.

When they finally arrived, it was almost anticlimactic. All of a sudden, the hallway opened up into a vast chamber. Computer terminals lined the walls, buzzing and flickering with incomprehensible numbers, crystals lying haphazardly on top of them or hooked up to crude cables. The floor was covered in chalked-out runes and summoning circles, along with the detritus of a dozen rituals. And on the other side of the room, her back turned to them—Shadow Weaver. For a long moment, there was silence, broken only by the hum of the ancient machines.

"Well?" said Shadow Weaver. She didn't turn around, her hands still busy mixing strange-colored liquids in a silver bowl. "Do you perhaps have something to say?" Catra stepped forward into the room, her tail bristling.

"It's over Shadow Weaver" she drawled. "Just come quietly, and we'll make this easy for you."

"Oh, do be *silent* child" replied the sorceress. "I wasn't talking to you and I don't have time for your usual antics. Adora. Come here. We have much to discuss." Adora didn't say anything. She watched as Catra visibly deflated, her tail wrapping around her legs, her shoulders hunching. Then, deliberately, she propped herself against the wall.

"That was a direct order from your commanding officer Shadow Weaver" she said quietly. "I advise you to obey it." Shadow Weaver finally turned around, eyes blazing.

"What?" she snapped.

"Horde General Code of Regulations 567.32.8, Part XI, Subsection 4, 'Any and all soldiers of the Horde will obey without question or hesitation the orders of their legal superiors'" said Adora, staring at the floor. "Catra is Generalissimo of the Etherian Horde, recognized and confirmed by the Command Council of Force Captains, sitting in joint session. Obey her orders." Shadow Weaver *hissed*.

"We do not have time for this nonsense. Do you know what is at stake here?"

"No. Maybe you can explain it to Commander Catra during your interrogation back home." Shadow Weaver's fist clenched, a pale fire flickering around her fingers.

"I have tolerated your childish games long enough. Didn't I teach you better than this?"

"You taught me to obey regulations" muttered Adora. "Horde General Code of Regulation 438.08.3, Part III—"

"Adora" broke in Catra, staring at the other girl. Her ears were flat against her skull and her tail was lashing back and forth. "You've made your point. But just *talk* to the woman or we'll be here all day."

"Fine" grumbled Adora. "Shadow Weaver, what do you *want?*"

"Only what I have always wanted child." Her voice was an amused lilt again. Light seemed to glisten on the jagged crack running down the centerline of her mask. "To help." Catra barked a laugh, and Shadow Weaver shot a glare at her. "That is what none of you have ever grasped—I am but a humble servant. I served Mystacor faithfully until they turned their backs on me, and then I was a loyal advisor to Hordak until he too betrayed me."

"And what, now you want to help *us?*" asked Adora skeptically. "How, by sending in spies and saboteurs? By plotting a coup against the Horde?"

"I want to help *you* Adora. I want to help you achieve your destiny. And I want to help you defeat Horde Prime."

"We don't need your help. We've been—"

"Yes, yes" interrupted Shadow Weaver, waving a dismissive hand. "I know all about your preparations. Signing your little treaties, stockpiling your tanks and guns and airplanes, your little toys. It's not going to help."

"It's not about *weapons!*" said Adora. "What we've been doing—it's about building an alliance, about unifying Etheria, about bringing together everyone under one roof. That's what's going to defeat Prime, if he ever shows up."

"Speak for yourself" muttered Catra. "I *like* my tanks." Shadow Weaver ignored her.

"Adora……I have stood aside for years now because I know that you do not wish to hear my advice. But you cannot afford these childish indulgences anymore. He's coming. He's coming *soon*." Adora felt a shiver go down her spine.

"How…..do you know that?"

"One can feel……certain signs, if one is able." The sorceress raised a palm towards the ceiling. "The forces of the planet have been disturbed. The magnetic field is fluctuating, the magical energy of Despondos is……shifting. Pulsing. Bending. Soon, even those ridiculous incompetents at Mystacor will be able to sense it. There is a force, outside our little dimension, a force vastly more powerful than anything we have seen. And it is seeking us. Someday soon my children the sky is going to crack open and our doom will be upon us. And I assure you, your pathetic little alliance is not ready for that day."

"So……let me guess." Catra's words dropped into the frigid silence that Shadow Weaver's speech had left behind. "You have some *amazing* weapon that can turn the tide if we *just* listen to you?"

"No" said Shadow Weaver. She pointed at Adora. "She does." Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Holding out on us, are we Adora?" The other girl shook her head.

"No! I mean……I don't think so?" Shadow Weaver began to pace, her long robes fluttering around her. The *click-click-click* of her shoes on stone echoed in the cavern.

"You carry a weapon out of this planet's most ancient history child, the mantle of the legendary warrior that the ancient Etherian tribes prayed to for protection." Her voice had taken on the familiar cadences of a lecturer, amusedly ironic. "There are inscriptions carved into the living rock a thousand years ago depicting that sword of yours—did you ever *once* question whether it was more than just a simple tool for bashing your enemies with?"

"Light Hope said……she said I need it to balance the planet" said Adora. Her eyes flickered, trying to follow their old teacher's steady march back and forth across the floor. "And in Mara's message she mentioned……a weapon?"

"At last" murmured Shadow Weaver. "I am glad to see that not *all* of my lessons were wasted. Yes, precisely. What you are carrying is a class-one command module, the priority activation key for this entire *planet*."

"Excuse me?" snapped Catra.

"It could defeat Horde Prime?" asked Adora. Shadow Weaver laughed.

"Child, if my research is correct, it could *annihilate* Horde Prime. It is more power than you dream of. The First Ones built…..something into the very heart of this planet, a construct of old magic and new technology that dwarfs anything that we can understand today. I still cannot breach the core protocols, but with She-Ra…..."

"So that's what you've been up to" said Catra. "You're hacking the planet!"

"Crude, but accurate, I suppose" said Shadow Weaver. Catra glowered at the mysterious computer terminals and magical paraphernalia that lined the walls, spelling out a story in a language she didn't speak. "I have learned much while you children played. And now? I freely offer my knowledge as a gift."

"And the spying?" asked Adora. "And the attack on Catra?" Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"I needed information and tools. Don't expect me to apologize for my methods. As for the Horde?" Her tone darkened for a moment, and her eyes flashed. "I gave decades of my life in service to them. I have *no* intention of letting it be squandered by an incompetent who's in far over her head."

"In other words, you were trying to build up a power base to take over the planet with once you unveiled this *super-amazing* weapon of yours" said Catra. "This *incredible* weapon, one so *stupendous* that we don't even need to see any evidence that actually *exists* before surrendering!"

"It……it makes sense Catra" said Adora very quietly. She was staring down at her sword, swaying gently at her hip. "Given some of what Light Hope has said……." she looked up at Shadow Weaver. "Is this……is it called the Heart of Etheria?" The words seemed to echo strangely in the ancient room, vibrating in the dead air.

"*Very good* Adora" said Shadow Weaver. "I always knew you had what it took, no matter how many times you squandered it on half-measures and—well, no matter now. Come. With my help, you will obliterate Horde Prime. You will bring balance to Etheria. Your kingdom and friends will be safe, even—" she nodded at Catra "—that pet of yours."

"You're just……offering all this to me?"

"The Heart of Etheria may only be operated by the She-Ra. I wish only to help you fulfill your destiny Adora. It's all I've ever wanted. Once you control the Heart, you may rule—or guide, if you prefer—the world as *you* see fit. I am but a humble servant. Now, let us begin. I suggest we start by running a full thaumatological analysis of that sword of yours. Then, we can—" Catra tuned the words out, the buzzing in her head drowning everything else out. *Adora would try and pin her against the wall so that Shadow Weaver could nail her with a spell.* She unsheathed her claws, moving one hand to her belt. *Smoke grenade as soon as Adora started moving, dodge the sword, dodge any spells, get on top of those computers where they can't use magic. Adora's between her and the door, but there are passageways deeper into the structure. Destroy something shiny and expensive, make them angry, duck into the corridors and run. Draw them in, take them out one by one—*

"How *stupid* do you think I am?" Adora's voice cut through Catra's inner monologue like a clarion call. She was staring at her old mentor, eyes blazing. "I spent my whole *life* in one of your cages, did you really think I'd climb into another one?"

"You are making a very serious mistake child." Shadow Weaver hissed.

"No, I'm not." She unsheathed her sword. With a murmured incantation and a flash of light, She-Ra was standing there, sword pointing unerringly at the sorceress. "Surrender."

"I had hoped for so much *better* from you Adora" said Shadow Weaver with a sigh. "But if you insist on being a foolish child—" she pressed a key on one of the consoles. There was a roar from outside—not just one roar, a thousand roars, mixed up and rolled together, the primal scream of a thousand monsters waking up all at once. Even through fifty meters of concrete it seemed to shake the walls. "This was a First Ones Command Center, my dear children." Catra swore she could *hear* Shadow Weaver's smirk. "I may not have been able to access Light Hope's sealed files, but influencing those……creatures outside was easier than I expected. I allowed you to enter my sanctum because I hoped you would be……reasonable. You won't find it so easy to leave."

Everything then started to happen at once.

Shadow Weaver jerked her hands, and Catra felt something *pulse* through her teeth and tail as magic surged through the room.

"Catra! B-6!" shouted She-Ra. Catra moved without thinking, rolling across the floor, her back *slamming* against She-Ra's, her arms sliding up into the guard position specified by Horde Combat Maneuver Beta-6. Above, the shadows shifted suddenly. Black fur flickered in the darkness, and red eyes blinked to life as a dozen screaming creatures dropped towards them. Catra's claws scythed, grappling with one of them, blocking its attempts to claw her face off, and tossing against a far wall. Two more hit the floor and bounded at her. She knocked one aside with a booted foot, then nailed the other with a flashbang grenade, sending it running off squealing. She could hear the *hum* of She-Ra's sword blocking and parrying just over her shoulder, and her muscles meshed against her back in a pattern so familiar from hundreds and hundreds of hours on the training fields that she could read the other girl's movements and intentions as they shifted. More of the creatures leapt at them from the shadows, and they spun together, claws and sword knocking them back or blocking them. There was another *pulse* of energy, sending chills through Catra's fur.

"Right three and turn!" she shouted, and felt She-Ra moving instinctively in response, twirling three steps to the rights and slamming her sword into a blocking position, just in time to miss a rippling blast of black fire that slammed against the far wall, melting the concrete.

"You'll have to do better than that!" sneered Catra.

"I had forgotten just how tedious you children could be" replied Shadow Weaver. She raised a hand, tendrils of fire curling around her fingers—

That's when the wall exploded.

A whirlwind of stone shards swept across the chamber, and computer terminals exploded like firecrackers. Through the haze of dust Catra could just make out what looked like a man leaping through the gaping hole where the wall used to be, long hair and beard framing a grizzled face.

"Shadow Weaver!" he roared, spinning a wooden staff and hurling bolts of purple fire towards her. "I've found you at last!"

"Who in blackest night are you?" snapped the sorceress. She raised her palm and flickers of energy slammed across the room, disrupting or deflecting the firebolts.

"I'm the King of Beast Island!" he shouted. "Shouldn't have lowered your defenses Shadow Weaver. Now I've *got* you!" Coruscating beams of light leapt from his staff, only to be swallowed by spasms of darkness that leapt to meet them.

"Whoever you are, you will find only your doom here" said Shadow Weaver. She slammed her palm down on another key. Panels in one of the (unexploded) walls screamed open, rusty gears wrenching into action for the first time in centuries. Two massive crab-like constructs scuttled out, silvered claws reaching for the intruder.

"Will somebody tell me what's going—" Catra started to ask plaintively. At that point, three of the monsters took the opportunity to make another attack, and she went down in a tangle of claws, fur, and fangs. She managed to slam one against the floor, dislodging him, then rolled, keeping her arms between their claws and her face. Their hot breath stank in her nostrils, and their eyes seemed to glitter with malice. She could hear She-Ra shouting something, and one of the little beasts screaming. The room rotated around her as she rolled—she saw the First Ones robots reach the intruder, she saw whorls of purple lights slamming into them, she saw Shadow Weaver's fire leaping into the fracas and rebounding into another bank of crystals and computer terminals, electronics *howling* as energy flooded through their ancient systems. She managed to get her claw around one of the monsters and toss him away, but the third one was wrapped around her throat now and she couldn't—there was a blinding flash of light in a color that Catra couldn't quite identify, and then she was hurling through the air. Distantly, she realized that she was tucked under She-Ra's arm and that the protector of Etheria was leaping through the gaping hole in the wall out into the night of Beast Island. She squirmed uncomfortably. "What are you *doing*—" she started to shout.

That's when the room behind them exploded.

This was turning into a really bad day.

They crashed into the underbrush, their fall broken by bushes and branches. Sharp, pointy branches. With lots of little clingy bits. Wet, slimy cling bits. Catra rose to her feet, cursing.

"Are you ok?" asked She-Ra. She, *of course*, looked flawless.

"Fine, fine" growled Catra, trying to disentangle a bramble from her hair. Her arms pulsed with pain where something or other had ripped through her uniform, and she was pretty sure there was a bite mark or two on her leg, but she ruthlessly ignored them. Behind them, the spire was burning, the

entire upper half of the First Ones structure engulfed in flames that billowed up the walls.

"Do you think—y'know—that they're……gone?" asked She-Ra.

"No such luck" said Catra, pointing to the conflagration, where little bursts of black and purple light still flickered back and forth. She-Ra nodded.

"So…..now what?" Catra just looked at her. She looked like some of the mosaics Catra had seen on her state visits to castles in Bright Moon, the firelight gleaming on her cheekbones as she stared firmly into the darkness. Her sword hung loosely from one hand, her immaculate costume standing out in stark relief against the dark green and brown of the surrounding jungle. It was the perfect picture of the Noble Warrior, Ready to Face Evil.

"You didn't listen to her" said Catra abruptly. She-Ra blinked.

"What?" she said, looking more like an actual human being.

"Shadow Weaver" said Catra. "She offered you all that power and you just…….turned it down."

"Well, yeah!" She frowned. "Wait, did you really think I'd fall for that?" Catra's ears flattened and she looked away.

"The *last* time someone offered you limitless power to desert your friends you didn't have a problem with it" she muttered. She saw a flash of light out of the corner of her eye, and Adora was standing next to her again.

"Is that why you think I left the Horde?" she asked softly. Catra shrugged.

"I know, I know, I *know*, you had your reasons, you don't have to defend yourself to me. But you still did it. You still left me behind to save the world. I guess that's what makes *you* a hero."

"Catra, did you—down left!" Catra dropped like a rock, and Adora's sword swished through the air where she'd stood, bisecting a giant scorpion. Catra hissed, and her eyes focused on the swaying trees right behind them.

"B-2!" she shouted, and Adora leapt into the air, letting Catra spring underneath her and bat away the giant millipede that had been dropping towards Adora's unprotected back. The surrounding jungle echoed with whistles and shrieks, and very abruptly Catra remembered what Shadow Weaver had been yammering about right before the walls started exploding.

"Eyes front" she hissed. "Something big moving twenty paces downwind, get ready to—" Adora grabbed her shoulder and she jumped.

"Catra, did—"

"Is this really the time?" snapped Catra. But Adora had a mulish look on her face, and Catra knew there was no point arguing with her.

"Yes. Catra, did you *really* think I would side with Shadow Weaver against *you*?" Catra jerked away from her, tail lashing. The buzzing in her head was loud again, and something very old and very painful deep inside of her snapped.

"Why not?" she shouted. "You've been doing that my whole life! You've always taken her side. You've always supported her. You let her do whatever she wanted and then—one day!—you tell me that you saw the Horde burning a few buildings or whatever so you just *had* to leave me behind to go off and play warrior princess with your new friends. Do you know what know what it was like there without you?" To her disgust, she realized

she was crying. Her head hurt and there was a humming in her ears and she was just so tired of everything. "I hate you!" she screamed.

"I thought you *wanted* to take over the Horde. That's what you told me. You said you didn't need me anymore." said Adora quietly.

"I wanted to rule the Horde with *you!*" she yelled. "I needed a friend and—and you were gone and Shadow Weaver said it was my fault and I could tell that Lonnie and the others blamed me and then Hordak promoted me and and—they would have destroyed me if I hadn't taken over. It was either rule or die and I didn't intend to go down without a fight. But don't you *dare* talk to me like you're my friend!" Adora stepped forward, and before Catra could stop her, wrapped her arms around her. She bristled in protest, but there was something undefinably comforting about the warmth of Adora's body heat radiating into her fur. Suddenly, her head felt better. Clearer. Like it had been wrapped in a woolen blanket that had been yanked away. "Um. What are you doing?" she said at last.

"Hugging you."

"Um. Why?"

"Because I love you." Adora blushed. "I mean, because I care about you. Because you're important to me. And I—I've been a bad friend but I—I'm *never* going to leave you again. Do you understand? *Never*." She was making that Noble Warrior face again, the light from the burning fire reflecting in her bright blue eyes. It was so stupid. So pointless. So…..so *Adora*. Part of Catra wanted to scratch that the expression off her face but—

"Do you promise?" she found herself whispering instead, and Adora squeezed her tight.

"I promise." There was a *crash*, and something with yellow fur, glowing red eyes, and way too many legs came

charging out of the trees towards them, roaring. The spell broke, and the two girls leapt aside as it swung its tusks towards them. Catra sprang into the air and landed on its back, grabbing hold of a thick tuft of hair. The beast howled with rage and shook itself, but she clung tight.

"What happens if you need to save the world again?" she called out. Adora grinned as she ducked underneath the monsters' legs.

"I'll figure out a different way this time!"

"What if there *isn't* a different way?" There was a flash of light as Adora transformed again, and She-Ra smirked up at Catra.

"I'll find one anyways. Because that's what heroes do." Her sword gleamed in the darkness as more creatures swarmed out of the jungle towards them and the Protector of Etheria stood to meet them.

"Are you kidding me?!" Catra shouted. She reached up, neatly clipped off a tree branch, caught it as it fell, and slammed it into the back of her impromptu mount's head, leaping clear as the stunned beast fell on top of half-a-dozen of its comrades. "That is the stupidest, inanest, corniest, most ridiculous thing I have ever heard in my *life* you insufferable—" the rest of her tirade was lost as she vanished under a rising tide of fur, fangs, wings, horns, and teeth.

Catra never could remember how long they fought. It was just an endless montage of snapshot images—hot breath blasting in face, teeth scraping along her arms, the vibrations running up her legs as she kicked something *hard,* the hammering beat of her heart as she whirled and ducked and danced in the moonlight, She-Ra glowing like a burning city as she hacked and slashed her way through the maelstrom. Again and again they came together and split apart, flowing through Horde combat forms like they were

back on the Fright Zone training grounds, synchronizing their movements without the need for any communication beyond the occasional gesture or shout. *This* was what the Horde had tried to drill into its recruits. *This* was what it meant to be in squad together—the instinctive, reflexive knowledge that comes from living and working together your entire life. She was too busy then to think it through, but later on Catra realized—that had always been her dream, as a child. Her and Adora, back-to-back, side by side, fighting against the world. Maybe that explained the joy that had been surging within her as an entire island of monsters did their best to tear her to pieces.

She noticed, dimly, when a massive back and purple fireball blew the top of the spire off completely, sending a rain of concrete and basalt shrapnel scattering across the forests. But she didn't have the spare mental bandwidth to realize what it *meant* until the whip of crackling black fire lashed out of the night sky and hit She-Ra.

Catra was halfway up a tree, slashing at a giant spider that was trying to follow her, when she heard Adora scream. The other girl was standing in a clearing, sword outstretched, probably in the middle of striking some Heroic Pose. Lightening was crawling across her now, wrapping around her sword and dancing down her arms and legs as she stood paralyzed. Catra didn't think. You don't have to think in combat. She flung herself out of the tree, sailing above the snapping teeth and claws of the beasts below until—*Fire, black fire, crawling up her nerves, climbing though her bones, blazing through limbs until she could hear the keening whine of the magic rippling through her—she hit the ground, gasping for breath.*

"*Enough*!" Shadow Weaver drifted to the ground, her cloak billowing around her in the wind. There was a new hairline fracture down her mask, and her robes looked charred and burnt, but her eyes were blazing with rage. Slowly, reluctantly, the monsters drew back. "This farce has gone on far too long. Surrender yourselves now." Catra chuckled weakly.

"So much for only wanting to help us, huh?" She coughed as pain flickered through her limbs, suppressing it with the ease of long practice.

"I will help you by saving this planet, despite your pathetic efforts to stop me." Behind her, silhouetted by the burning remnants of the spire, could be glimpsed the metallic gleam of more First Ones sentinels silently climbing out of the ruins of the Command Center. Catra sneered.

"What, you're gonna take over the world with some scary monsters and a few robots? Good luck."

"It will suffice for now. And with you out of the picture, I think the Horde will soon bow again to its rightful master. Rest assured, I will have troops enough to……*convince* people to see things my way."

"Don't be so sure of that" muttered Catra. "Anyways, what happened to your *spectacular* superweapon? Can't you just snap your fingers and get whatever you want now?" Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"Planetary annihilation is a blunt instrument. Now. You children have delayed matters long enough." She made a gesture, and a pair of the crab-like robots scuttled forward towards Adora. Catra lurched to her feet.

"*No*" she hissed. Shadow Weaver sighed.

"Your determination is admirable, if pointless. Believe it or not, I truly regret this." She raised a hand. Catra braced herself.

That's when the sky exploded.

Light flared, blindingly, as a hole a five hundred feet wide ripped itself open above Beast Island. The moonlight vanished as something massive glided through, a towering spindle of parapets and towers and ramparts curling around each other……Catra

blinked as she finally made the connection from the Enemy Recognition Silhouette Files.

"Is that…….*Mystacor*?" she asked.

"Impossible" snapped Shadow Weaver. "The power necessary to transport it thus…..that so-called High Sorceress wouldn't *dare*….." All along the edges of the floating castle lights began to pop into existence, hovering circles of incandescent runes and sigils and glyphs slowly rotating. Then……they fired. Beams of magical energy slammed into the ground, hundreds of them scything through the air. Robots exploded, beasts ran roaring for the safety of the jungle, trees vaporized. There was a keening wail in the air as far too much magic pulsed into existence at once. Catra thought she could hear Shadow Weaver scream in rage but she was too busy, grabbing Adora's arm and dragging her into the lee of a boulder. She looked up as the flying city of magic drifted overhead, raining destruction down below.

"This is the worst mission ever" she said. "Just in case anyone was wondering." Adora stirred, and opened her eyes.

"Are we dead?" she murmured. Catra cocked her head and thought.

"I don't *think* so" she said finally. "Being dead wouldn't be this annoying."

"That…..makes sense" muttered Adora. She tried to get up and gasped, wincing. Catra caught her arm.

"Hey" she said gently. "Be careful. That lightning can linger for a while in your muscles, ok?"

"Thanks" said Adora, leveraging herself up slowly. She gave Catra a weird look.

"You're, uhhh, pretty familiar with it, huh?" Catra just grunted. After a minute of slow, careful stretching Adora said plaintively "Catra, is that *really* Mystacor up there?"

"Looks like it" said Catra, flicking her ears as another hail of magical thunderbolts slammed into the ground.

"Huh" said Adora. "This really has been the worst mission ever."

"I *know*, right!?" There was a flash of purple light, and a tiny pink-haired woman popped up. Her eyes lit up with relief when she saw the two girls huddled behind the boulder.

"Adora! Oh, thank the stars you're alive!"

"Glimmer! It's great to—*ouch*!" Glimmer had punched her in the stomach.

"You *jerk!*" she screamed. "You—you—I don't even have words! You can't just vanish like that without telling us!"

"I left a note!" protested Adora, still clutching her belly.

"'*Gone to fight Shadow Weaver on Beast Island with Catra. Be back soon'*. You call that a note?! What is your problem? And stop laughing!" The last was directed at Catra, who was snickering.

"Good to see you too Sparkles" she said. "You can't punch me—it'd be an act of war."

"Fine" grumbled Glimmer. "But I'm still mad at you both." Another blast of energy hammered out of the sky, disintegrating a nearby tree.

"I appreciate the reinforcements and all princess—"

"Why? I assumed you'd be *fine* trying to conquer Beast Island by *yourselves* like *maniacs*—"

"But could you maybe ask those idiots up there to be a little less trigger happy?"

"Oh" said Glimmer. "Um. Probably not. Aunt Casta was, uhhhhh, really happy about getting to just blow some stuff up for once. Like, *really* happy. I don't think she's in a mood to listen to me." Two more trees faced the might of Mystacor and perished forthwith.

"Great" muttered Catra. "See, this is why I prefer the Horde. We might have not magic but we've got discipline by Hordak." Glimmer rolled her eyes and pulled out a tracker pad. She tapped a button.

"Force Captain? Yeah, I found your boss. You deal with her." She tossed the pad to Catra, who grinned and caught it.

"Boss? Is that you?"

"Lonnie! It's good to hear your voice. What've you brought me?"

"I've got the 164th and 203rd Light Infantry and three maniples of Bots, ready to get off this floating monstrosity before it remembers castles can't fly."

"Well, we wouldn't want to disappoint you. Get moving, form a defensive perimeter around this sector. Once it's secured, see if you can salvage anything from the command center. Remember, this is an extraction, not an occupation. Move fast, don't get bogged down."

"Understood Generalissimo!" Zip lines began to drop over Mystacor's edge, and squads of Horde troops dropped to the ground, wielding shock-sticks and laser-rifles as they rushed into the night. Here and there gunfire erupted as they found a still-functional robot or a beast with more stubbornness than strength. Catra watched the activity with a smug smile.

"So. What happened to Shadow Weaver?" asked Glimmer. Adora shrugged.

"Not sure. I lost track of her when everything started exploding."

"She fled like the coward she is!" A voice boomed out. Footsteps crunched on the jungle floor and the three girls spun around to see an old man trot out of the burning forest. Much of his beard had been burned off, as well as most of his robes, but he was smiling and spinning his staff.

"Oh" said Catra, not lowering her claws. "It's you. Who are you exactly?"

"Didn't I mention?" The old man frowned. "I'm the King of Beast Island! Good day to you all!"

"It is?" asked Catra. He chuckled grimly.

"Girl, do you know how long I've been waiting for this day? I've spent *years* plotting my revenge against her. I've been waiting *weeks* for her to lower her defenses! And now I've finally defeated her!" He paused, deep in thought. "Well, sort of. Close enough!" Glimmer frowned.

"Sorry, do I know you? You look……familiar."

"Oh well, that's to be expected" he said cheerfully. "You're all hallucinations so of course you'd recognize me." There was silence for a long moment.

"We're…….hallucinations?" asked Adora carefully.

"Of course!" bellowed the stranger. "That's what happens when you spend a few months or years or whatever it's been alone on Beast Island. *Though*, I must admit, you're more interesting than usual." He stroked what was left of his beard, gazing up at the floating castle still raining death and destruction down below. "Let's see now—*you're* an Etherian princess of some kind" he pointed at Glimmer, "*You're* the legendary ancestral protector of the planet—She-Woman, right?"

"Um. She-Ra, actually" said Adora.

"That's right! It's amazing what you remember when you're having a mental breakdown—I must have read that storybook about you *decades* ago! And—who are you?"

"Generalissimo Catra, Supreme Commander of the Horde, Protector of the Kingdom of Scorpions and the Kingdom of Dryl" snapped Catra. The self-proclaimed King nodded sagely.

"So *that's* what Hordak looks like under that armor. I've always wondered." Catra blinked slowly.

"Ok…….sure."

"Wait, wait do you think *Shadow Weaver* was a hallucination?" asked Adora.

"Hmmmm." The old man thought for a moment. "*Probably* not. Hallucinations usually don't hurt that much. Or last for months. I expect the lot of *you* will be gone in an hour or two!" He beamed at them. Adora and Glimmer stared back.

"I guess…….that makes sense?" ventured Adora.

"Are you sure I don't know you from somewhere?" asked Glimmer.

"I *told* you, as a hallucination you'd obviously recognize the hallucinator. Stands to reason, yes?"

"I *suppose* so……"

"Though now that I think about it……." He looked up again with a frown as more magical thunderbolts obliterated another grove of trees. "Hallucinations don't usually level half the forest…….*huh*……."

"Wait a minute" said Adora. "You saw Shadow Weaver run? Which way did she go?"

"That way!" The old man pointed with his staff. "Between those trees and down the gully towards the big rock with the blue lichen that spits poison. I would've followed but I was still crawling out from under some debris."

"Okay, but did you ever visit Bright Moon? I feel like I've seen……a picture of you somewhere?"

"It's only been a few minutes! Do you think we can still catch up with her?" Adora turned to Catra and blinked in surprise. She was already gone.

The only sound was the chirping of the blood-crickets and the occasional shriek of a banshee-bird as Shadow Weaver slipped out of the trees and into the clearing. Some cataclysm had struck here once, uncountable years ago, blasting a hole in the forest, leaving only a towering slab of stone. With a muttered incantation, Shadow Weaver raised her hands, and a circle of crystals affixed to the rock began to glow with unearthly light. Then a dart shot out of the gloom, hitting one of the crystals and shattering it with a torrent of sparks and a howl of misdirected magic. Shadow Weaver froze, then sighed, brushing back her hair with the concentration of someone who would otherwise be smashing something valuable.

"Ah Catra. You just don't know when to quit, do you?" A quiet chuckle drifted out of the jungle. She was sprawled on a branch, tail flicking back and forth below her. Her eyes glittered in the darkness.

"*I'm* not the one trapped on Beast Island. Maybe you should be the one to think about quitting."

"Perhaps. How did you find me, anyway?"

"I can smell the stink of your magic from a mile away, witch." She dropped the ground, landing with catlike grace. "You're not gonna make this difficult, are you?" The buzzing was

back in her head, a whispering ache somewhere deep inside that just made her want to curl up on the floor. And yet……it was easy to ignore. All she had to do was remember the warmth of Adora, wrapped around her.

"*Difficult*" said Shadow Weaver slowly, in a tone of voice that would have sent a younger Catra scurrying for the air vents. "*Difficult*. You stupid, ignorant child—don't talk to me about *difficult*."

"I'll take that as a yes, then" said Catra. She unsheathed her claws and stepped towards her former guardian.

"Adora could have saved the world!" shouted Shadow Weaver. "Again and *again*—why do you insist on dragging her down into the mud with you? She has a destiny; do you understand that? I would have guided her, helped her—and together we would have destroyed Horde Prime. All you had to do was *get out of the way.*" Catra froze, ears flattened against her head.

"Adora never lets anyone stop her from doing the right thing" she said softly. "Not me, and certainly not you. If you she says she doesn't need your help to save the world then—she doesn't. End of story."

"You are all going to regret this." Catra shrugged.

"Probably. I regret a lot of things. But that doesn't stop me from doing 'em."

"And when Horde Prime cracks open the sky and descends upon this planet—"

"Adora will be there to stop him. And so will the Horde."

"The *Horde*" Shadow Weaver sneered. "Honestly Catra. Even you should know better than that. Without Hordak, without me, without even Adora, what even *is* the Horde anymore?"

"The Horde is unity for Etheria" said Catra. "It's protection for the people who need it. It's a home for those without one. It's order out of chaos, and a weapon that will guard this planet from anyone who tries to attack it."

"Oh Catra. Please don't tell me you believed all those stories I told you when you were young." Catra laughed.

"Don't be stupid. Nobody believed that junk except Adora. And maybe Kyle. But it's going to be true. Do you understand me? I'm going to take your lies and I'm going to *make* them true!" Shadow Weaver clapped her hands together.

"Brave words child. Perhaps I should have trained you as an orator instead of a soldier. You could hardly be worse—" Shadow Weaver moved instantaneously, her arm swinging out even as she spoke, a bolt of black fire leaping from her palm towards Catra and—

—ricocheting off a blazing sword hovering only a few inches from her nose and blazing off into the forest.

"*Enough*" said She-Ra. Golden light seemed to fill the clearing, and her voice seemed to echo off the edges of the world somehow. It must be that Hero thing again. Then she winked at Catra.

"Adora. There is still *time*. We can still salvage something if we act now."

"Now, I believe Catra was taking you into custody? If you want to continue—"

"Foolish child! Can't you see that that *filthy* creature has led astray for again? Don't you understand—" Catra didn't quite make out what happened next. She heard She-Ra say

"Oh *shut up* already!" She saw a blur of golden light, and heard the meaty *thunk* of a sword pommel slamming into

someone's head. Then Adora was standing over an unconscious Shadow Weaver, scowling down at her. Catra coughed.

"Are you, um. Are you allowed to do that? Being a hero and all that."

"Oh" said Adora. She rubbed the back of her head, looking sheepish. "I mean……I did it? So, I guess so?"

"Good enough for me."

They walked in silence back through the jungle, footsteps trudging on the wet loam and loose scree of the forest floor. A bound and blessedly insensible Shadow Weaver was slung over Adora's shoulder.

"So" she said after a while. "I'll always do the right thing, huh?" Catra's ears flattened.

"Shut up" she muttered. Adora giggled. After a minute Catra said

"So. You love me, huh?" Adora turned bright red.

"Shut up" she grumbled. Catra chuckled.

Dawn was breaking as they arrived at the ruins of the First Ones Command Post, warm moonlight just starting to creep along the upper edges of the forest. The fires still burned dimly, here and there, but sorcerers and Horde troops were hard at work, hauling anything that looked remotely valuable or interesting out of the wreckage. In the distance you could hear the occasional *zap* of shock-sticks or *pop* of magic as a monster got a little too close for comfort.

"I guess……..we won?" said Adora.

"Yeah" said Catra. "I guess we did." She stared intently at a rock a few inches from her foot. "Um. Thank you. For coming with me. I might not have—I probably wouldn't—I *definitely*

couldn’t have done it without you. Thank you.” She felt Adora’s hand squeeze her shoulder.

“That’s what friends do” she said. “We help each other. And—we’re friends, right?” Catra sighed.

“Yeah” she said. “I guess……we are?” She shot a glare at Adora. “Don’t gloat.”

“I won’t, I won’t!” She looked insufferably smug but Catra supposed she could put up with that. It was, despite everything, turning out to be a *good* day. Shadow Weaver had been captured. Her base had been destroyed. Everyone was still alive. There was some new weird mystical nonsense to figure out but wasn’t there always? Everything had worked out—Catra’s eye caught on something as she surveyed the battlefield and she frowned.

“Hey Adora. Why are Glimmer and that crazy old man crying and hugging each other?”

End Notes

- So remember how I said how I hoped that the next one would be easier to write? HAHAHAHAHA. Nope! I have basically known for months that this is where I wanted the story to end up and I have been putting off getting here because I wasn't at all confident of my ability to actually write it. There was just too much I needed to cover and not enough time and space to do it. I think I managed to hammer it together in a way that works though, and hopefully you'll agree. :) I'm planning a follow-up to this that will expand on some of the emotional developments and hopefully THAT ONE will be easier to write than the last few have been.

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